

VALUES-BASED CHOICES

Aligning decisions with your core values

Understanding Your Values

In a world filled with options and external pressures, it's easy to make choices that don't truly align with who we are or what we aspire to be. Values-based choices are decisions that are grounded in your core principles and beliefs. They are about understanding what is fundamentally important to you and using that understanding to guide your actions and decisions.

Your values are the guiding stars of your life. They represent what you deem to be good, right, and important. When you make choices that are in harmony with your values, you tend to experience a greater sense of purpose, satisfaction, and authenticity. On the other hand, choices that contradict your values can lead to feelings of regret, dissonance and unhappiness.

Identifying your core values is the first crucial step. These aren't fleeting preferences but enduring beliefs that shape your perspective and behavior. Think about the qualities you admire in others, the causes you feel passionate about, and the principles you'd want to live by even when no one is watching. Your values are unique to you and can evolve over time, but they provide a stable foundation for decision-making.

The Power of Values-Based Decision Making

Why bother with values-based choices?

- **Authenticity:** Live a life that is true to yourself.
- **Clarity:** Reduce decision fatigue by having a clear compass.
- **Purpose:** Connect your actions to a meaningful direction.
- **Resilience:** Navigate challenges with inner strength.
- **Satisfaction:** Experience deeper fulfillment from your choices.

When you operate from a place of values, your decisions become more straightforward. Instead of getting bogged down by short-term gains or external opinions, you can ask yourself: "Does this choice align with my commitment to honesty?" or "Will this help me foster stronger connections?" This internal compass not only simplifies complex decisions but also builds confidence and self-trust. It's about moving from reactive choices to proactive ones, where you are the conscious architect of your life's path.

Activity: Discover and Apply Your Values

Let's put this into practice. This activity will help you identify your core values and start applying them to your decision-making.

Part 1: Identify Your Core Values

1. **Brainstorm:** Take some time to reflect. Consider the following prompts:
 - What qualities do you admire most in people you respect?
 - What makes you feel proud of yourself?
 - What principles do you believe are essential for a good life?
 - What causes or issues do you feel passionate about?
 - When have you felt most alive and energized? What were you doing?
 - Imagine your 80th birthday. What would you want people to say about how you lived?
2. **Review and Refine:** Look at your brainstormed list. Group similar ideas together. Try to distill them into single words or short phrases. Aim for a list of 5-10 core values that resonate deeply with you.

Some common examples include: Honesty, Compassion, Growth, Creativity, Security, Freedom, Connection, Courage, Integrity, Health, Learning, Contribution, Respect and Adventure.

Part 2: Apply Your Values to a Decision

1. **Choose a Decision:** Think of a decision you are currently facing, or one you have made recently, that felt challenging or ambiguous.
2. **Analyze with Values:** For each of your identified core values, ask yourself:
 - How does this value relate to the decision?
 - What would making a choice aligned with this value look like in this situation?
 - What would making a choice *contrary* to this value look like?
3. **Weigh and Decide:** Based on your analysis, which decision path best honors your most important values? You might find that one value is more dominant in this particular situation, or that a compromise is needed.

Reflection:

- How did this process feel? Was it helpful in clarifying your decision?
- Were there any values that were difficult to apply? Why?
- How can you integrate this values-based approach into your daily life?

Next Steps

Continuously revisit your values. As you grow and experience new things, your priorities may shift. Make identifying and living by your values an ongoing practice. Keep your values visible, perhaps write them down and place them where you can see them daily. The more you practice making values-based choices, the more natural and rewarding it will become.